

[Return to Search](#)

Conversation with Ogotemmêli

Author(S): Griaule, Marcel

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 215

Culture (OWC): [Dogon \(FA16\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1931-1947

Coverage Date: 1946

Place Coverage

Sanga; Bandiagara Circle, Mopti Region, Mali

Section Title(S): The Signs Of The Zodiac

Sagittarius (the archer) is recalled by the smith armed with his bow and standing erect on the celestial granary, which is also his female twin with her four members lifted like a sort of framework supporting the sky. He is connected with water, because he is a Nummo, and because he extinguished the fires launched against him with water from his leather bottle.

[772](#)
[Cosmology](#)

[773](#)
[Mythology](#)

[821](#)
[Ethnometeorology](#)

The corresponding sign of the Zodiac, the arrow with a ball in the middle of the shaft, is no doubt the spindle piercing the spindle-whorl. The arrows shot by the smith into the sky and into the granary were spindles; to the one shot into the vault of heaven was attached the thread of the descent, which unrolled from the spindle planted in the roof of the granary. The granary itself was an enormous spindle-whorl, which had served as a target for the arrow.

[772](#)
[Cosmology](#)

[773](#)
[Mythology](#)

[821](#)
[Ethnometeorology](#)

The *Pisces* (fishes) of the Zodiac, twins connected by a streamer or a duct coming out of their mouths, also symbolize water. They appear on the north stairway of the celestial granary, attached to the Bozo. Fish and men are twins, and the Bozo is himself of water, being the first fisherman of the Niger and the master of the river. The Bozo maintain what is called a 'joking relationship' with the Dogon who traditionally refer to them as 'fish that walk on land'.

[648](#)
[External Relations](#)

[772](#)
[Cosmology](#)

[773](#)

[Mythology](#)[821](#)[Ethnometeorology](#)

It would seem, therefore, that the Zodiac of the Mediterranean peoples could be explained from the point of view of Dogon cosmology and metaphysic. But the European had no illusions about how such an argument was likely to be received by recognized specialists in academic circles. True, there were encouraging exceptions, brilliant minds which, though concerned mainly with classical studies, would regard remote civilizations with sympathy and surprise; enlightened amateurs, drawn to the African because of his art, and bold thinkers interested in speculations of an unusual character, seized eagerly on these problems. But they were lost in the crowd.

[121](#)[Theoretical
Orientation](#)[171](#)[Comparative Evidence](#)[772](#)[Cosmology](#)

Has it not been established once for all that the African has nothing to give, no contribution to make, that he cannot even reflect ancient forms of the world's thought? Has he not always been relegated to the level of a slave? 'Consider the carvings of the great civilizations of antiquity! Where do the Negroes figure in these? Why, in their proper place, among the lesser races! What influence do you attribute to them?'

[121](#)[Theoretical
Orientation](#)

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)